independence period. The government has attempted to eradicate the use of the Mon language. Mon political parties have been harassed and delegitimized by the authorities. Mon political leaders have been detained and human rights violations against the population are commonplace.

The Mons are more urbanized than most ethnic minority populations. Many Mons end up working in Thai gem mines and many women have been forced into the sex industry. A significant problem for the Mons is their location, which lies in the path of potential natural gas pipelines, as well as their proximity to the gem-mining routes from neighboring Thailand. This unfortunate location problem for the Mon makes them one of the most vulnerable and persecuted ethnic minority groups in Myanmar. The fact that the Myanmar authorities finally recognized a separate Mon state in 1974 did not lessen the tension.

Naga

The Naga population is located in the Putkai range in northern Myanmar. A significant portion of the Naga population resides across the border in India. Many Naga converted to Christianity during the colonial period. The Naga independence movement has been active since the 1950s. Known as fierce warriors, the Naga are renowned for tough resistance against both the tatmadaw as well as the Indian military. The Naga have been denied any formal recognition by the Myanmar authorities. As Indian cooperation with the state of Myanmar increases, the potential threat to the Naga is also accelerating. The constant state of war has caused severe economic hardships to the population. The future status of the Naga may be more precarious than most of the ethnic minorities of Myanmar.

Rakhines and Rohingya

In many ways, the most volatile situation in Myanmar is in the Arakan territory. The majority Buddhist population known as the Rakhine is in a state of turmoil with the minority Rohingya Muslim minority population. The tension between the groups has increased in recent years.

As with a number of ethnic problems in Myanmar, geography plays a significant role in the heightened tensions. The region lies on the frontier of